

Episode 113: New Year Special Edition – *STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM*

Notes (Probably Middle Part)

While last time we had "first snow fell!" in cold Tokyo, this week Tokyo is warm enough to make you think "Is this spring?" But well, another cold wave will probably return soon, so it's just a momentary "spring-like?" weather.

Tempted by such weather, I rode my bicycle from my Nakano home to Toei's Oizumi studio for the first time in a while. About 10 kilometres in about an hour at a leisurely pace. Probably the first time in about three months. Along the way, the new Shakujiikoen station building, which had been under serious construction, was now quite completed.

What I realised keenly after riding my bike for the first time in a while was that hybrid cars are scary! They don't make sound, you see—hybrid cars. The running sound is too quiet. When we're riding bicycles on the road, we can usually tell when cars are approaching from behind by engine noise, right? But these hybrid cars are incredibly quiet when running on motor power. They're quiet like "Are you a ninja?" and you really don't notice even when they're right behind you. I had several close calls because of this (sweat).

At night, there are headlight beams so even hybrid cars' approach is easy to detect, but what's especially scary is wide roads in residential areas during the day. If you're riding without noticing they're approaching and accidentally drift toward the centre line... you know? Really scary. That's why iPods while cycling are absolutely out of the question.

This seems to be becoming a problem. With both hybrid cars and cyclist populations increasing these days, I hope the automotive industry, Ministry of Land Infrastructure and Transport, and police will implement countermeasures soon.

Now then.

This week continues the *STRONG WORLD ONE PIECE FILM* notes.

We somehow cleared the trailer hurdle. Using almost all cuts that would be used in the theatrical main feature, it became a pretty good trailer. But that trailer couldn't actually be used as-is in the main feature. Everything was still "temporary."

While the animation and art needed considerable corrections, the "colours" in particular were still temporary colour direction. "Temporary colour direction." We certainly got Oda-sensei's "OK" on the basic character colour coordination in time, and the trailer was painted based on that coordination, but that was just the basic basics. It was "trailer colours."

As with any work, characters (cels) and art (backgrounds) require balance adjustment work.

I think probably all colour designers do this, but when we start creating character colours initially, we first build character colours according to some kind of "basic brightness value for characters" that each designer holds within themselves. Once we've created them all, we place those completed characters on basic backgrounds (art boards) to see (adjust) the balance between backgrounds and cels.

I also build based on the standards within myself.

For human characters, generally the whites of eyes or teeth are the whitest and brightest parts of the body, right? So in my case, I first create a balance between eye white brightness and skin brightness, and using that as a standard, I arrange colours overall while assuming volume under sunlight in normal daytime colours.

This thinking was basic both for the colours I first showed Oda-san that got rejected and for the colours I reorganised based on Oda-san's colour concepts and showed him again.

So, the trailer. When I saw the art boards and actual backgrounds that came from the art staff, I groaned involuntarily.

"Hmm, amazing! It looks really good, but..." I said.

Actually, it was quite a bit—or rather considerably—more clearly defined, with denser colours and tones than what I'd anticipated for background art.

"Ah, at this rate, the characters will be overwhelmed (sweat)"

That's right. When placing characters on backgrounds as-is, the characters' colour volume would be overwhelmed by the background volume, making the characters completely inconspicuous. This was especially true since Chief Animation Director Sato's character drawings had thin, delicate lines, making them even more prone to getting buried in the backgrounds.

For example, if this had been a TV work, characters are central, so we might apologetically ask the art staff to tone down the backgrounds a bit based on character requirements, but this was a theatrical work after all. This background art was for screen density that would look good projected on that big screen, so while there might be director retakes regarding colour tone, scaling down the volume from here was impossible. That meant we had to raise the volume on the cel data colours to a level where they wouldn't be overwhelmed.

So I hastily applied uniform level corrections to all completed trailer painting cuts before they went to photography. Thanks to this, we achieved some degree of balance, but it was emergency treatment under time pressure. For me, it was still quite insufficient. While still images might look okay at first glance, this is animation after all—when characters move, they looked somewhat weak. While that balance was acceptable for the trailer, I wanted to work on it more for the main feature.

So I readjusted the character balance against backgrounds for the main feature and recreated the standard "normal" colour direction.

I adjusted the strength of colours themselves so that the character colour balance created when lined up on pure white backgrounds would look the same when placed on high-density backgrounds. I adjusted colours darker and raised saturation levels without breaking the balance between characters.

The key here is that doing this too much makes characters overly assertive on screen, while too little makes their presence fade. Characters must have a solid presence against backgrounds. But without proper harmony, it doesn't work as movie imagery.

Additionally, based on verification from creating the trailer, I fine-tuned the colour separation for several costume parts. While I'd initially tried detailed colour coding and separation, parts that didn't look good on screen or seemed likely to become retake sources later were organised and corrected without significantly changing the original impression.

And one more thing. The theatrical promotional poster was drawn and coloured by Oda-san based on the finalised colour sample set, but this had subtly different part separations. So I made minor corrections to match the poster too (wry laugh).

At this point, there was one more major correction: Robin's eye colour.

The director and assistant directors pointed out "It's blue in the TV version," so I once modified Robin to have blue eyes, but this always felt wrong to me somehow. But in this poster, Oda-san had finished her with brown eyes after all! So I passionately convinced Director Sakai in front of the colour proof of the poster displayed at the staff room entrance. Thus Robin returned to the light brown eyes matching the colour illustrations.

Based on this completed "basic"—so-called "normal"—colour direction, we then moved into each scene's colours, scene-by-scene colour design.

(10.01.13)